

***UNFLINCHING LOOK*** Director Patrick Graham has directed his third true-crime documentary

DOCUMENTARY ▼

# SEEKING ANSWERS

Director **Patrick Graham's** latest documentary asks questions about the 2020 Hathras case

Early in the process of making any true-crime documentary, director Patrick Graham asks himself a series of questions that help him decide if he really wants to tell that story. High on that list is the question—"Is there any value in telling this story?" It was no different when he started working on Zee5's *Hathras: 16 Days*. The three-part documentary is a chronological retelling of the 2020 case in which a 19-year-old Dalit woman in Hathras was raped, murdered and eventually allegedly cremated without her family's consent.

"Unfortunately, there is nothing extraordinary about a young woman—especially Dalit—being raped or gangraped. The reason this case stands out is for multiple reasons, including the victim's forced cremation," the 43-year-old director explains. It also helped that Tanushree Pandey, a key journalist on the ground, is attached to the documentary as an executive producer. "Not only is Tanushree a narrator of sorts in the documentary; having her helped us get access to many people we needed to speak with."

Through the making of this documentary, Graham and his team were cognisant of the alternate theory floated by many in the mainstream media that this could have been an honour killing. Mulltiple interviews with the victim's family over the past three years helped bring clarity. "I just felt that the honour killing narrative was an extremely cynical attempt to discredit the family," says Graham.

*HATHRAS: 16 DAYS* DOES **NOT USE VIOLENCE FOR ENTERTAINMENT**. IT IS A WELL-RESEARCHED RECREATION OF THE HORRIBLE CRIME

*Hathras: 16 Days* is this London Film School alumnus's third true-crime documentary in as many years. Much like *Dancing on the Grave* (2023) and *The Dupatta Killer* (2025), this one also doesn't use violence for entertainment. Instead, it asks uncomfortable questions. "The backlash against the family and the reporting of this crime do suggest there was a concerted effort at every level of society to shut this investigation down. It seemed like there was a larger interest in keeping that ancient hierarchical structure of caste in place. You have to wonder—who does that benefit?" ■

***—Karishma Upadhyay***

# THE LISTICLE

**Upcoming theatrical and OTT releases to look out for**



▲ **JUN. 4,** *Theatres*

## PEDDI

Ram Charan, star of *RRR*, is aiming for bigger leagues as the solo hero leading a gigantic production with actors from across India, an A.R. Rahman soundtrack, and a national award-winning director, Buchi Babu Sena. The Telugu-language *Peddi* is Sena's sophomore project. Ram Charan plays a rural athlete using brawn and more brawn to fight injustice.

